

Adjectives

ADJECTIVES ARE WORDS OR PHRASES THAT MODIFY OR DESCRIBE NOUNS OR PRONOUNS.

A noun by itself does not offer much information. If a man wanted to buy a shirt in a store, he would need to narrow down what he was looking for by using descriptive words like *thin* or *silky*. These words are known as adjectives.

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- If you are unsure whether a word is an adjective or something else, see if it answers questions such as: **What kind? Which one? How much? How many?**
- Adjectives should be used **sparingly**, for effect. Too many adjectives can make a sentence difficult to follow.

Describing words

Most adjectives describe attributes (characteristics) of nouns or pronouns and answer the question *What is it like?* They are used to compare one person or thing to other people or things. Adjectives are usually placed directly in front of the noun—a position known as the attributive position.

the **weary** painter

adjective in attributive position → ← noun

The **weary** painter took off his
and ate a **day-old Chinese**

GLOSSARY

Attributive position When an adjective is placed directly in front of the noun or pronoun that it is modifying.

Clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb.

Linking verb A verb that joins the subject of a sentence to a word or phrase—often an adjective—that describes the subject.

Predicate position When an adjective follows a linking verb at the end of a sentence.

Proper noun The name given to a particular person, place, or era, which always starts with a capital letter.

Compound adjectives

Compound adjectives are made up of more than one word. When two or more words are used together as an adjective in front of a noun, they are usually hyphenated. This shows that the two words are acting together as a single adjective.

This two-word adjective means “not fresh today.”

day-old meal

“Proper” adjectives

Some nouns can be modified and used before other nouns as adjectives. These include proper nouns, such as the names of places. Adjectives formed from proper nouns should always start with a capital letter. They often end in -an, -ian, and -ish.

Chinese
Australian English
Roman